Sir Alexander Fleming was the first person to discover the antibiotic penicillin in the year 1928. The antibiotic penicillin was obtained from the fungi *Penicillium chrysogenum*. It is used to treat diseases such as tetanus and diphtheria. The antibiotic, streptomycin is obtained from *Streptomyces* bacteria to cure various bacterial infections. Eg. Plague.

Vaccines

Vaccines are prepared from dead or weakened microbes. Edward Jenner was the first person to discover small pox vaccine. He coined the term vaccination. When the vaccine is injected to the body of a patient, the body produces antibodies to fight against the germs. These antibodies remain inside the body and protect from future invasion of the germs. Therefore, vaccination is otherwise called as immunization. Eg: MMR vaccine is given for preventing Measles, Mumps and Rubella. BCG (Bacille Calmette Guerin) vaccine is given for preventing Tuberculosis.

16.8.2 Agriculture

Natural fertilizer

Microorganisms are called as decomposers because they act upon degradable wastes. During the process, nitrates and other inorganic nutrients are released into the soil, making the soil fertile. This compost is called as natural fertilizer.



Figure 16.13 Types of Biofertilizers

Nitrogen fixation

Rhizobium bacteria living in the root nodules of leguminous plants enrich the soil by fixing the atmospheric nitrogen as nitrates which are essential for the growth of plants. Some free living bacteria in soil, like Cyanobacteria Nostoc can also fix nitrogen biologically.

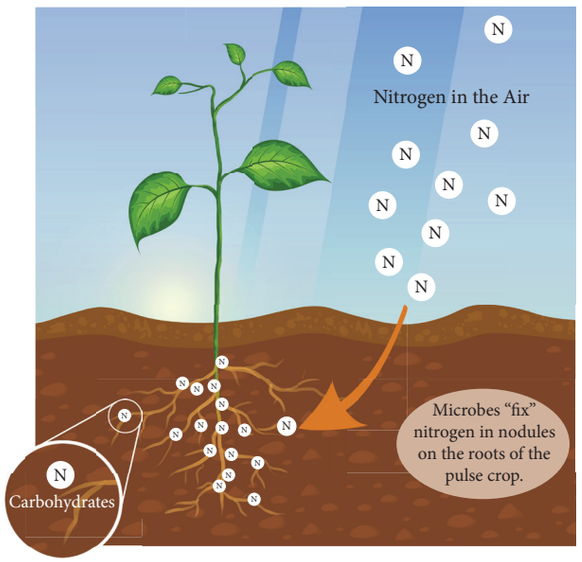


Figure 16.14 Nitrogen fixation in plants

Bio-control agents

Microbes are used to protect the crops from pests. Some of them are given below.

- *Bacillus thuringiensis* (Bt cotton) helps to control insects.
- *Trichoderma* (Fungi) helps to protect roots and controls plant pathogens.
- *Baculoviruses* (Virus) attack insects and other arthropods.

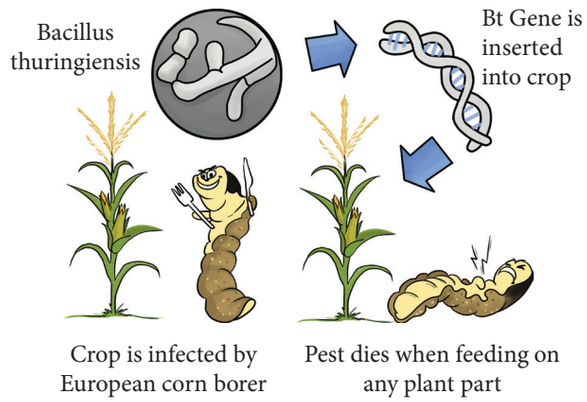


Figure 16.15 Biocontrol agents

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